

# From the mat to the firing line

A wrestler in the making, **Himanshu Dhillon** found his calling with a rifle and announced himself with two Asian Games silver medals.

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**O**n Monday morning, the 21st of September, just as he does every day, Shamsheer Dhillon sent his son Himanshu a motivational message over WhatsApp. But this day wasn't like any other. Shamsheer first wished Himanshu a happy birthday. Then he told the newly turned 21-year-old Himanshu, who was also about to make his debut at the Asian Games, to make the day a special one. *"Jo bhi ho, ek medal jodna hai Bharat ke liye. Kaunsa bhi jude woh tere pe hai* [Whatever happens, we need to add a medal to India's tally. The colour of the medal depends on you]," he said.

Himanshu would do just that. At the Aichi Prefectural General Shooting Gallery, he first shot a 630 in the qualification round. That helped the Indian team, which also

included Rudrankksh Patil and Parth Mane, secure a team silver in the men's 10m air rifle event.

Then, in the final, he first got past former world champion and teammate Rudrankksh and also came within sniffing distance of double Olympic champion and World No. 1 Sheng Lihao before eventually bringing home another silver in the individual event.

As they stood on that finals range, hearts raced with the tempo of marathon runners, while muscles strained to prevent even the minutest natural movements of the body. Himanshu had to fight hard to win his first individual senior international medal. It took Lihao breaking his own Asian Games record to keep the young Indian debutant at bay.

Over the course of the final, Himanshu shot three scores of 10.9, the perfect centre of a ring that's less than the width of a ballpoint pen's nib.

